

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Instead of 'Be Careful': 20 Phrases

Supporting safe, confident risky play · Ages 2–5

Children need to climb, balance and test their limits. These phrases help them notice risks and make good choices, instead of just being afraid.

What the research found

- ○ A review of studies found risky outdoor play was linked to more physical activity, better social skills and resilience (Brussoni et al., 2015).
- ○ Thrilling play may help children master fears naturally (Sandseter & Kennair, 2011).

Point out what you see

- ○ “That branch is thin.”
- ○ “The ground is slippery.”
- ○ “There's a sharp edge here.”

Help them notice

- ○ “Where will you put your foot next?”
- ○ “Is that rock steady?”
- ○ “How will you get down?”
- ○ “What's your plan?”

Encourage problem-solving

- ○ “Take your time.”
- ○ “Try using your hands too.”
- ○ “I'm here if you need me.”

When to step in

Step in for real dangers: heights above their own head, roads, deep water, sharp objects.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Brussoni, M., et al. (2015). What is the relationship between risky outdoor play and health in children? A systematic review. International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health, 12(6), 6423–6454.
Sandseter, E. B. H., & Kennair, L. E. O. (2011). Children's risky play from an evolutionary perspective: The anti-phobic effects of thrilling experiences. Evolutionary Psychology, 9(2), 257–284.

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